

AGE OF VICE
by Deepti Kapoor
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 560 pages

Deepti Kapoor's new novel, *Age of Vice*, arrives amidst a thrum of fanfare. *The Guardian* declared it "India's answer to the *Godfather*", it's been at the heart of intense bidding wars by TV producers, and it sits on several most-awaited-titles lists of 2023.

The already-hailed second novel from Kapoor opens with a chilling road accident. A drunk driver in a speeding Mercedes kills five people late one night in Delhi. From here, the novel picks up speed as it journeys through 'Delhi life', the shiny and the ugly, and a world of thugs and parties (political and otherwise).

"I never had any intention to write a crime thriller, it's constantly surprising to me [that] it's now being slotted in that category," says Kapoor, who lives in Lisbon with her husband. "It starts with a crash that leaves five people dead and there is a mystery at the heart of the novel, but then, you know, it goes into so many different directions. It's hard to slot your own novel in any genre. I think of it like a Bollywood masala film, it has a little bit of everything."

The 548-page doorstopper begins with one crime and then steadily expands into more crimes, gang wars, power struggles, and a doomed romance. Three characters provide a foundation for the world of the novel. There is Ajay, a backward-caste boy from Uttar Pradesh, who is sold into labour but works his way through to become the right-hand man of business scion Sunny Wadia. Sunny is the second pillar, a brash and beguiling heir to a vast empire, a classically spoilt hedonist. And then there is Neda, a young reporter ("who is not me," Kapoor emphasises) who gets entangled with Sunny and his gang. The novel roves through Uttar Pradesh and Goa, but is essentially set in Delhi, where power and money constantly brush up against squalor and despair. It's equal parts social commentary and ripping yarn, leavened with suspense and unexpected turns.

"There was a germ of the idea of writing about the rich and privileged in Delhi, but then that very soon became a novel about inequality, extreme inequality and post-liberalisation India," says the author.

Kapoor was in Delhi for a decade from the time she was 18, first in college and later writing trends and lifestyle stories as a journalist. She drove the length of the city, partied with the privileged—her peers, after all—and had a ringside view of socialising in the early 2000s. "I always had an idea that I might write about those years," she says. "I happened to be right there in the early aughts when Delhi was transforming really rapidly." Reporting assignments gave her opportunities to meet a cross-section of people and observe and attend events of all stripes. It was an "intense relationship" with the city.

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Kapoor's debut novel was set in the capital and so will be her next two—*Age of Vice* is the first of a planned trilogy. "It [Delhi] is where very significant life-changing events happened to me in a very concentrated period of time, which started with the illness and subsequent death of my father, and then, a couple of years later, the death of my first boyfriend," says Kapoor. *A Bad Character* (2014), her first novel, opens with a young woman talking about her dead boyfriend; it also features a motherless youngster navigating Delhi. Kapoor summarises the book as being about "grief, trauma and desire". It was shortlisted for three literary prizes.

By the time Kapoor turned to fiction, she had quit journalism and moved to Goa as a yoga instructor. She counts Marguerite Duras, Joan Didion, Roberto Bolaño and Patricia Highsmith among her literary influences.

Kapoor admits there is some pressure that comes with being one of a handful of internationally published Indian novelists. But, also, "American publishing has vastly changed," she says. "It's not like they're looking for *the* novel from India anymore, that talks about everything." But an Indian reader might leave with other impressions. "For Indians, it might be this idea that, why is this novel being published? Why has this novel found an American or an international readership? Is it because, you know, she's trying to pander to the West?"

Kapoor has been working on developing her fiction for television, as well as on new novels. She believes they will be less grim. "I promise that after [the *Age of Vice* novels], the other novels will not be like this," she laughs. "They will not be bleak and full of despair." ■

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